



7th Grade English Language Arts

OPTIMA ACADEMY ONLINE · COURSE SYLLABUS · 2026–2027

Full Year · Grade 7

FACILITATOR

Optima Academy Online Faculty

FLORIDA COURSE

M/J Language Arts 2 · #1001040 · Full-year course

GRADE LEVEL

Grade 7 (Middle School)

EMAIL & OFFICE

Your facilitator's email is posted in Canvas · 239.673.2801 (OAO Front Office)

OFFICE HOURS

Posted in Canvas · weekly study hall and VR workshops

FORMAT

On-Demand (also offered live on the VR campus)

About this syllabus. This is the plan for the course as designed. It is a full-year 7th grade English Language Arts course; On-Demand scholars pace through the six modules across the four quarters of their enrolled year. On-Demand and live-school sections share the same content and expectations; exact pacing, scheduled dates, and a few activities may vary from section to section and term to term. Your facilitator will confirm the specifics for your section.

COURSE OVERVIEW

M/J Language Arts 2 builds scholars' skill as readers, thinkers, and writers through six works of literature spanning three centuries: *Gulliver's Travels*, *The Call of the Wild*, *A Christmas Carol*, *The Outsiders*, a short-story unit built around Richard Connell's "The Most Dangerous Game," and *The Scarlet Pimpernel*. Each week pairs three literature lessons with two grammar lessons, a vocabulary Word Study, a Quick Write, and two hands-on activities on Optima's VR campus, all building toward one project per module: a written piece, a creative piece, and an immersive VR scene that bring the module's reading together. Scholars keep a personal Reading Journal for each work studied and take part in one structured discussion per module. Across the year, scholars move from narrative writing toward argumentative writing, built step by step (a thesis, evidence and explanation, a counterclaim, a conclusion), while steadily building command of grammar, mechanics, and academic vocabulary. Scholars also learn to cite what they quote in MLA format and to close a piece of writing with a Works Cited entry, the same conventions they will use in high school.

WHAT SCHOLARS WILL LEARN TO DO

- Read six works of literature across genres, analyzing how setting, point of view, and narrator shape a story's meaning.
- Compare themes and their development within and across texts.
- Notice and name figurative language, irony, and rhetorical devices, and explain their effect on tone and meaning.
- Write personal and fictional narratives using narrative technique, point of view, and figurative language.
- Build an argumentative essay step by step: a clear thesis, evidence and explanation, a counterclaim, and a conclusion.
- Grow academic vocabulary every week from that week's reading, using each word intentionally in writing.
- Follow the rules of standard English grammar, punctuation, and mechanics at grade level.
- Cite quoted evidence in MLA format and finish a piece of writing with a Works Cited entry.
- Research a topic beyond the novel: find sources, judge whether a source is reliable, tell a primary source from a secondary one, and put an idea in your own words without borrowing someone else's.
- Read poems written in set forms, including a sonnet and a villanelle, and write one of your own.
- Write a real letter that states an opinion, registers a complaint, or requests information.
- Complete a hands-on VR activity nearly every day and a personal Reading Journal for each work studied.

BIG PROJECTS & MILESTONES

The course builds toward one finished project per module. Target dates below follow a **sample full-year pacing**; On-Demand scholars pace to their own enrolled term and Live sections follow the class schedule, keeping each milestone roughly in order.

PROJECT / MILESTONE	COURSE PLACE	SAMPLE TARGET	WHAT YOU TURN IN
Gulliver's Travels Final Project	Module 1 · Weeks 7–8	by Oct 23 (Q2 Wk1)	A short written argument (M365 Word doc), a Lilliput/Brobdingnag creative contrast piece, an immersive VR scale-contrast scene, and a reflection. Evidence is cited in MLA format, with a Works Cited entry.
The Call of the Wild Final Project	Module 2 · Week 6	by Dec 4 (Q2)	An argumentative essay on Buck's transformation, a creative component of your choice, a VR transformation scene, and a reflection. Evidence is cited in MLA format, with a Works Cited entry.
A Christmas Carol Final Project	Module 3 · Week 2	by Dec 18 (Q2 ends)	A book cover capturing the novella's central theme, a written reflection citing the text in MLA format, and a short VR scene staging Scrooge's transformation.
The Outsiders Final Project	Module 4 · Week 7	by Feb 19 (Q3)	A literary-analysis essay on a theme of the novel, cited in MLA format with a Works Cited entry, a creative component (a character collage or a short research piece), and a VR thematic scene.
Short Story Final Project	Module 5	by Mar 5 (Q3 ends)	An original suspense short story with an ironic twist, a short author's note, and a VR story scene.
The Scarlet Pimpernel Final Project	Module 6 · Week 9	by May 21 (Q4)	An argumentative essay on courage and disguise, cited in MLA format with a Works Cited entry, a creative component of your choice, and a VR thematic scene.

IMPORTANT DATES — 2026–2027

Aug 12, 2026	First day of school	Sep 7	Holiday (Labor Day)
Oct 9	Quarter 1 ends	Oct 12	Holiday (Columbus Day)
Nov 11	Holiday (Veterans' Day)	Nov 23–27	Thanksgiving break
Dec 18	Quarter 2 ends · fall semester ends	Dec 21–Jan 1	Winter break
Jan 5, 2027	Classes resume	Jan 18	Holiday (MLK Day)
Feb 15	Holiday (Presidents' Day)	Mar 5	Quarter 3 ends
Mar 26–Apr 5	Spring break	Apr 6	Classes resume
May 28, 2027	Quarter 4 ends · last day of school	May 31	Holiday (Memorial Day)

ASSESSMENT & GRADING

30% Daily Practice (reading, Word Study, grammar POP! quizzes, VR activities)	25% Composition (weekly Quick Writes)	30% Module Projects (written, creative, and VR components)	15% Friday Check-ups, discussions & Reading Journal Checks
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HOW THIS COURSE IS DELIVERED

This course is offered in two formats that share the same content, assignments, and expectations: an **On-Demand (asynchronous)** section you pace yourself, and a **Live (synchronous)** section that meets on a schedule on Optima's VR campus. The two overviews below explain how each one works. Find the one that matches your enrollment.

ON-DEMAND (ASYNCHRONOUS) LEARNING

In the **On-Demand** section you move through the course at your own pace within each quarter, guided by due dates that keep you on track. All assignments for a quarter open at its start and close at its end. Because the course is On-Demand, there is no grade penalty for missing an individual due date — but any assignment not completed by the end of the quarter receives a **zero**, and assignments submitted in the final **14 days** of a quarter receive a **10% deduction**, so steady pacing matters.

Attendance is measured by assignment completion. Per school policy, a scholar who completes no assignment for ten consecutive school days, without notifying the school of an absence in advance, may be dropped from the course. Completion means a **sincere attempt** — real effort on real work. Rushed work, wrong or corrupted files, irrelevant or nonsense submissions, AI-generated filler, and word-salad responses do not count.

 **You are never on your own.** A live facilitator grades your work, gives feedback, and hosts a weekly study hall and VR workshops.

LIVE (SYNCHRONOUS) LEARNING

In the **Live** section you join scheduled class meetings on Optima's VR campus, where your teacher leads instruction in real time and you learn alongside classmates. The readings, assignments, and projects are the same as the On-Demand course; what differs is the pacing — a Live section moves through the material together on the class schedule rather than at each scholar's own pace, and class time is also used for discussion, questions, and guided practice.

Attendance is measured by presence and participation. You are expected to attend the scheduled live sessions, on time and ready to take part. If you must miss a class, notify the school in advance; your teacher will let you know how to make up the work and any material you missed. As in every Optima course, completing your work means a **sincere attempt** — real effort on real work — and assignments still open and close with each quarter.



You meet regularly with a teacher. The class gathers throughout the week in VR and on Microsoft Teams for live instruction and discussion.

APPROPRIATE USE OF AI

Optima scholars are preparing for a world shaped by artificial intelligence, and learning to use these tools with good judgment is part of that preparation. You are welcome to use AI tools to **support** your learning — to explain a concept a different way, check your understanding, or brainstorm — unless a particular assignment says otherwise. What AI may **never** do is the thinking or the work an assignment asks of you: a reflection, a Quick Write, an essay, a creative project, or a discussion post must be genuinely your own. Submitting AI-generated text as if it were your own work is dishonest and, as noted above, counts as an insincere attempt. When you do use an AI tool on an assignment, say so briefly. Above all, build the underlying skill yourself — the goal is for you to be able to judge whether an AI's answer is any good, which you can only do if you can do the work without it.

LEARNING IN VIRTUAL REALITY

Optima is a virtual-reality school. Alongside your Canvas coursework, you will join immersive sessions on Optima's VR campus, where you meet teachers and fellow scholars, take part in live activities, and explore places and ideas you could not visit in an ordinary classroom. Keep your headset charged and ready for any scheduled VR sessions, and treat the VR campus with the same courtesy and seriousness you would a physical one. If you ever cannot get into VR for a session, tell your facilitator — there is an alternative way to take part so you do not fall behind.

BEING AN OPTIMA SCHOLAR

Optima's mission is an excellent, virtue-centered education, and virtue is at the center of this course as much as any other. Every scholar is expected to practice the seven virtues that shape life at Optima — **courage, courtesy, honesty, perseverance, self-government, service, and responsibility**. In practice that means: do your own honest work; treat everyone you meet in, through, or because of this course with respect, in writing, in discussion, and in VR; engage actively rather than passively; come to office hours to get help, meet other scholars, and get to know your facilitator; and take responsibility for your own pacing and progress. You belong to a house and a community of scholars, not only to a course.

WHAT YOU NEED & STAYING CONNECTED

- ✓ A computer with reliable internet and access to **Canvas**.
- ✓ A **VR headset**, charged and ready for the weekly immersive activities on Optima's VR campus.
- ✓ **Microsoft 365** (Word) with OneDrive, for the Quick Writes, Reading Journal, and Final Projects you create and submit.
- ✓ A notebook or binder, and pens or pencils, for notes and grammar practice.
- ✓ **A copy of *The Outsiders*** by S. E. Hinton, for Module 4 in the spring. This is the one book scholars supply themselves; any edition is fine, and a library copy works. The novel is still in copyright, so the course cannot provide the text the way it does for the others. Your facilitator will say when it is needed, well before the module opens.
- ✓ The other five works are provided inside the course. Nothing to buy or download.

Staying connected. Updates about this course are posted on the course's **Canvas** page; school-wide updates are posted in your **Homeroom Canvas** course. Check both regularly. Your facilitator holds office hours and is glad to help with the material, to meet you, or to talk through your plans — come by, or reach out any time by email.